

Chapter 47-2: Obsession

"What's happening? Has the judge's magic failed?" Ning Fuyi looked at her hands that had returned to human form and drew her divine sword from the prayer beads.

The cold wind around them grew stronger, and when she looked up, several ghost souls were already floating to the temple entrance, trying to enter but being blocked by an invisible barrier. That wasn't all - if one looked into the distance, countless overlapping ghost shadows could be seen surging from throughout the underworld.

The scene of thousands upon thousands of ghosts swarming toward the two of them was enough to send chills down even Ning Fuyi's spine, let alone Chu Qingqiu who already disliked ghosts.

"The judge said only one person entered the underworld. They're coming because they smell two people," Chu Qingqiu said urgently, stepping back to shield Ning Fuyi. "Remember to use as little immortal power as possible, or we might attract even more fierce ghosts from outside the underworld, making escape difficult!"

"Transforming back into an animal won't help either. After all, we're in the underworld where much of our magical power is ineffective," Chu Qingqiu seemed to guess Ning Fuyi's thoughts.

"They're getting in." Ning Fuyi held her breath. This Yama Temple was just a decoration with little incense. Moreover, countless ghosts were ramming against the walls, which soon developed cracks with many ghostly hands extending through them like insect legs, waving frantically in pools of blood.

With a thunderous crash, the Yama Temple completely collapsed. Chu Qingqiu suddenly grabbed Ning Fuyi's neck, pressing her through the wall cracks and running toward the back of the temple.

Though they had escaped the Yama Temple, there weren't fewer ghosts around them - flying overhead and crawling on the ground, they were everywhere. Ning Fuyi stepped over severed limbs and arms countless times, screams echoing around them while the sticky sensation made her nauseous.

"This way!" Chu Qingqiu's voice rang in her ear, followed by a white light cutting through the ghosts in front of them, sweeping clear a path. Chu Qingqiu's palm pushed against her back, and Ning Fuyi's body flew uncontrollably forward several zhang¹.

Ning Fuyi almost tumbled on the ground. When she turned around, she was surprised to find all the ghosts brushing past her to pounce only on Chu Qingqiu. Chu Qingqiu's white robe hem was completely invisible, surrounded entirely by those hideous faces.

Perhaps because she herself was of extreme yin nature, these ghosts seemed only interested in Chu Qingqiu.

An empty space quickly formed around Ning Fuyi. Watching Chu Qingqiu surrounded by countless ghosts with unknown circumstances, her phoenix eyes narrowed slightly. She used her fingertips to brush the disheveled hair from her forehead back behind her ears, then kicked away two headless corpses passing by and strode back into the fray.

On the other side, the white bone in Chu Qingqiu's hand was already whirling like a disc, her movements so fast they left afterimages, wrapping herself impenetrably. Ghosts continuously tried to bite her neck, only to be struck away by the white bone.

Though using only technique without immortal power, she temporarily protected herself, remaining untainted amidst the filth like a wisp of solitary smoke, her skirt hem not stained with even a drop of blood.

But the ghosts of the underworld were endless, and the ghost officers were nowhere to be seen. Chu Qingqiu's lips pressed into a straight line as a drop of sweat fell from her forehead onto the muddy ground. Immediately, several heads emerged from underground, desperately stuffing the sweat-soaked soil into their mouths.

Chu Qingqiu felt nauseous and coldly lifted her foot to stomp them back into the earth, but was inadvertently grabbed by the ankle. When her movement stopped, more hands seized her limbs, countless bloody hands clinging to her body like maggots. In her terror, Chu Qingqiu nearly got pulled underground.

At this moment, another pair of arms surprisingly encircled her waist. Chu Qingqiu inwardly cursed this lecherous ghost and was about to use immortal power again, when those arms actually pulled her backward. At the same time, a foul-smelling liquid sprayed around them. Every ghost that was splattered screamed and retreated, and all the ghostly hands clinging to Chu Qingqiu released their grip.

Chu Qingqiu's complexion finally softened somewhat. She realized it was Ning Fuyi and momentarily held her breath.

"This is..."

"Black dog blood²." Ning Fuyi answered, pulling out another bottle from her prayer beads and splashing it around, forcing the ghosts to make way.

Knowing they would come to the underworld, she had specifically sought some out for emergencies. Now it seemed indeed useful.

"They're chasing us again!" Ning Fuyi's dark eyebrows furrowed tightly. "Is there nowhere in this underworld that ghosts can't enter!"

As soon as she finished speaking, like a flash of inspiration, she and Chu Qingqiu looked at each other, then she quickly reached out to grab Chu Qingqiu's hand and ran toward the Bridge of Helplessness.

All the way, she wielded her divine sword, countless ghosts being struck into the ground. She stepped on those ghosts' skulls as she ran, finally seeing the tall Bridge of Helplessness and Meng Po on the bridge, working hard to brew soup and turning a deaf ear to worldly affairs.

When the two brushed past Meng Po, she finally looked up, wanting to ask in surprise, but was startled by the swarm of ghosts surging forward. She quickly stood up and waved her ladle, blocking the rioting ghosts at the other end of the Bridge of Helplessness.

"I can't hold them for long! Quickly enter the Red Spider Lily grove! You can hold out longer there!" Meng Po shouted at the top of her voice. Ning Fuyi quickly complied, pulling Chu Qingqiu toward the Red Spider Lilies.

Soon, the blood-red flowers were within reach. Compared to the storm behind them, the motionless silence here was even more eerie.

The two stopped in their tracks. Ning Fuyi turned back to say something, only then discovering that she had been holding Chu Qingqiu's hand all along. Their fingers were almost interlocked, Chu Qingqiu's fingers clearly defined, like soft silk, feeling smooth and supple in her palm.

It had been too chaotic earlier, and Chu Qingqiu had also just noticed this. She quickly withdrew her hand, lightly pressing her lips together as some color returned to her pale face.

"Let's go in." Chu Qingqiu said and started forward, but was stopped by Ning Fuyi.

"I saw it all - the wound on your hand." Ning Fuyi shook her head. "If you walk in like this, your feet will be ruined."

"But..."

"I'll carry you." The young woman suddenly crouched down, exposing her slender back to the woman. "I've tested it - these flowers don't affect me as severely."

Chu Qingqiu fell silent for a moment, but those ghosts had already broken through Meng Po's defense line, surging toward them like dark clouds with ghostly wails.

"Hurry up!" Seeing Ning Fuyi's urgency, Chu Qingqiu finally compromised and climbed onto her back.

The woman's body wasn't heavy, but her legs were long - just a little more and they would touch the petals. Ning Fuyi could only lift her higher with effort, then closed her eyes and stepped heavily into the flower cluster.

The flowers were silent. When petals fell on her legs, there was a faint sensation of pain, but nothing like Chu Qingqiu's wounds that went deep to the bone with just a touch.

She hadn't expected that someone who had died once would have less obsession in her heart than Chu Qingqiu. Ning Fuyi smiled self-mockingly and quickly ran into the depths of the flower sea.

Sure enough, those ghosts were blocked outside the flower sea, testing and probing but not daring to enter.

After all, once they stepped in, they would automatically become Red Spider Lilies, their souls forever buried here.

Ning Fuyi breathed a sigh of relief. She stopped in the center of the flower sea where everything became quiet around them, with only someone's heartbeat thumping audibly.

Chu Qingqiu's body was very light and soft, not like a woman who had lived for thousands of years. To steady herself, she placed her hands on Ning Fuyi's shoulders, but only rested them lightly, not daring to apply pressure.

"When I see that judge again, I'll definitely teach him a lesson. He nearly got us killed," Ning Fuyi tried to break the silence.

Chu Qingqiu didn't speak for a long while, then after a moment whispered in her ear: "Do you know when one's magical power disappears?"

"Of course..." Ning Fuyi's words stopped abruptly as she looked in shock toward the distant red-black sky.

Both fell silent for a long time, with only the whistling cold wind in their ears while the petals and stems remained perfectly still.

"If Divine Venerable crossed the Bridge of Helplessness, would you choose reincarnation or stay in this flower field?" Ning Fuyi suddenly turned her head and asked softly.

"Reincarnation." Chu Qingqiu said, looking at the young woman's profile. "I still have things left unfinished."

Ning Fuyi wasn't surprised by her answer.

She made a sound of acknowledgment: "I would stay here. If I could forget the pain of living in this world, that wouldn't be bad."

She wasn't someone like Chu Qingqiu who cared about the world. She had nothing left unfinished. In fact, if she died, it would be good for the world.

Chu Qingqiu's hand on her shoulder suddenly tightened.

Ning Fuyi stomped her feet with a relaxed air, changing the subject: "We can only wait here now for the next judge to come and get us out of this damned ghost place."

Carrying Chu Qingqiu, she wandered around boredly in a circle. Her sharp eyes noticed that the stems of those Red Spider Lilies seemed to have small characters carved in blood. Looking more closely, they were actually the names of dead people.

No one would remember them except themselves.

Ning Fuyi walked through the flower cluster, looking at names from who knows how many years ago as she walked. Walking and walking, she suddenly saw a stem without flowers that had become somewhat withered and yellow, quite conspicuous among the blooming flowers.

"Interesting." She raised her eyebrows and murmured, bending down to look. But Chu Qingqiu behind her seemed to suddenly tense up, reaching out to stop her.

Naturally, movement couldn't be faster than sight. She had already seen clearly, and her smile instantly vanished.

Glaringly carved there were three characters she couldn't be more familiar with:

Ning Fuyi!

Footnotes:

¹ **zhang (丈)**: A traditional Chinese unit of measurement, approximately 3.3 meters or 10.8 feet

² **Black dog blood (黑狗血)**: In Chinese folklore, black dog blood is believed to have protective properties against evil spirits and ghosts